CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SET / PRODUCTION DESIGNER IN THE AI ERA

The sets are still built by hand. There are just far fewer of them being built.

★ TL;DR — NO — under this title, as a general start. The pay is exact: median $75,240 (BLS, Set and Exhibit Designers, May 2025) — but growth is +1%, with ~2,200 openings a year nationally, most of them replacement. And the demand underneath is measured shrinking: FilmLA puts LA shoot days ~29% below the five-year average, with stage occupancy down from ~95% to ~62%. The roadmap below is the way OUT: the budget-crew-deadline brain that builds worlds is worth more in rooms that are growing. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

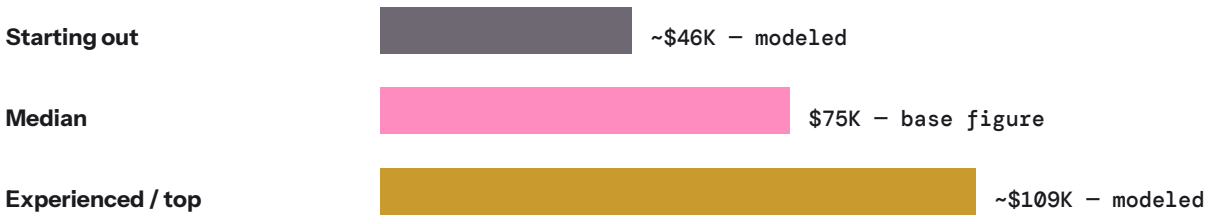
- Fails as a start because: this is a demand-side NO. The occupation adds only ~500 jobs in a decade on a 31,600 base (BLS, +1%), and its largest market is contracting — LA County motion-picture jobs fell from ~142,000 (2022) to ~100,000 (late 2024), and TV shoot days run ~53% below the five-year average (FilmLA).

- The title problem: 'Production Designer' is the department head — a senior credit above the BLS occupation, reached through the art-department ladder (art PA → dresser/buyer → assistant art director). The ladder's bottom rungs are network-hired in a handful of incentive hubs, and they're scarcer in a smaller production base.

- Still worth money: running a physical build — drawings, budgets, crews, deadlines, a space that must exist by Monday. AI took the front of the pipeline (concept boards and previs are now routinely generated); it cannot hold a tape measure. And budgets, crews and deadlines are project management — a +7% occupation.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Set / Production Designer is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SET / PRODUCTION DESIGNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Read scripts and design the spaces the story lives in
- ✓ Draw, model and budget sets, then supervise the build
- ✓ Source props, furniture and dressing; manage a small crew
- ✓ Stand on set solving problems while the shoot clock runs

Think: an architect and a foreman had a baby that grew up in a theatre — a brilliant trade, in a town that's building far fewer theatres.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
The front of the pipeline: concept boards, previs, look-development imagery and reference decks — historically junior art-department labour, now routinely generated before a human is hired.	Physical judgment: what a room must feel like, what a wall costs, what a crew can build by Monday. Budgets, materials and deadlines don't care how good the render looks.

⚠ **THE 2,200-OPENINGS MIRAGE: ~2,200 openings a year for the entire country, most replacing leavers, concentrated in a few hub cities and hired through networks. That's not a national job market — it's a guild door in a shrinking capital, and it doesn't open for a certificate.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Every project a new world: workshops, locations, builds, paint ✓ You literally watch your drawings become rooms ✓ Half art, half construction — nothing about it is a desk job	✗ Feast-or-famine bookings in an industry running ~29% below its own average ✗ Long build and shoot days, often far from home ✗ Budgets shrink; expectations don't

Good fit? You already run physical things — events, builds, crews, budgets — and can prove it. For you the exit is a translation: same machine, growing industry.
Bad fit? You need a fixed schedule, a guaranteed monthly rhythm, and a 'designer' title on a film set in 2027. All three are the scarcest goods in this market.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Project Manager	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Video Editor
BLS Project Management Specialists: median $102,320, growth +7%, ~76,500 openings a year — roughly thirty-five times this occupation's openings. A set build is a project: a fixed deadline (the shoot date does not move), a fixed budget, twenty trades, one space that must exist. You have already done the hardest version of this job — outdoors, at 5 a.m., with the weather voting. PM is that skill with a national market and a median ~$27K above the one you're leaving. First move: take your best production and write it as a project case study — budget held, schedule held, problems absorbed. That's a PM interview in a folder.	BLS Film and Video Editors and Camera Operators: editor median $75,420, growth +3%, ~5,600 openings a year. Editing demand is distributed — corporate, real-estate, event, wedding, social and streaming production buy finished video continuously — instead of concentrating in a few studio hubs waiting for shoot days to come back. Your visual storytelling and set literacy (what coverage exists, what a scene needs) make you a faster editor than a cold beginner. First move: cut a 60-second trailer-style piece from footage of a world you designed or dressed. The eye is the portfolio.

Smart move: If the ambition stays: aim it at the steadier half — exhibit, museum, retail and experiential design (the non-film half of the BLS occupation), or climb the physical art-department ladder inside an active incentive hub where productions actually are. Name it honestly either way: it's a business-and-network build, not a title you apply for.
Where you land after: You land where builds still have budgets: running projects at a $102,320 median, or cutting video for the distributed market that never waits for a studio greenlight. The worlds still get built — by you, on somebody else's growing calendar.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	INVENTORY YOUR	WRITE ONE	LEARN THE	GET A	APPLY AS

STEP 1 — Read the shoot-day numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the FilmLA figures yourself: shoot days ~29% under the five-year average, stages at ~62% occupancy
- Your asset isn't the designer title — it's running builds: budgets, crews, deadlines. That's what moves

STEP 2 — Inventory your production reps

FREE · 1 WEEK

- List every build, event or production you ran: budget size, crew size, deadline
- Write down the worst problem you absorbed and what it cost — that's PM gold

STEP 3 — Write one project case study

FREE · 1–2 WEEKS

- Pick your best production: scope, budget held, schedule held, problems solved
- Format it like a project report, not an art portfolio — numbers first, photos second

STEP 4 — Learn the PM toolkit

SELF-PACED · 2–4 WEEKS

- Scheduling, budgeting, risk logs, stakeholder updates — the paperwork dialect of what you already do
- A recognised PM credential can run parallel if a target employer asks for one

STEP 5 — Get a live rep outside film

FREE · 3–4 WEEKS

- Run one real project — an event build, a retail install, a renovation — end to end
- Capture proof: budget, timeline, one before-and-after number

STEP 6 — Apply as a project manager

FREE · ONGOING

- PM roles in construction, events, media and operations; lead with the case study, not the film title
- Keep Door B warm: one edited piece a month keeps the distributed video market open

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the FilmLA numbers, then list your builds with their budgets. The second list is the career.

□ Days 1–30: case study written; PM toolkit underway.

□ Days 31–60: one live project outside film run end to end; proof captured.

□ Days 61–90: applications out as a PM — or a portfolio of edited pieces if Door B wins.

 Day 90: you're the person who delivers physical projects on time — in a market with ~76,500 openings a year, not 2,200.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ BUILD WHERE THE WORK IS ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.